



Moustache begone!

Did you know that not one U.S. President has had the courage to grow facial hair in a 100 years? A hairy situation.



Terrabytes? Pshaw!

The entire Google Earth database comes in at a staggering, 20 Petabytes! And Google gives it away for free.

Budget Smartphone Battle

The big three under 8k

There's nothing we Indians like more than a bargain, except maybe our festivals. So, it is no surprise that companies like Motorola, Xiaomi and Lenovo have done well in the country. Budget phones from these companies, particularly Motorola and Xiaomi, have brought about a sea change in the smartphone market. The Indian consumer no longer looks at the price tag to determine quality, he or she looks at the value.

But, as our dear Uncle Ben once said, with great power comes great responsibility. The first generation budget phones from these companies were trendsetters, which automatically means that phones from the second generation have to be outright performers. We'll take the under 8k segment this time, and talk about three smartphones that perhaps provide more value than anything else in the market.

Our contestants here are the Xiaomi Redmi 2, Motorola Moto E (2nd Gen) and the Lenovo A6000. Note that we're using the 3G variants of the Moto E, and the 1GB RAM variants of the Redmi 2 and A6000. So, without further ado, let's jump right into it.



Price
₹6,999

Build and Design

People often mistake these aspects of a smartphone as a representation of its looks. Well, if that were true, then the Xiaomi Redmi 2 would win hands down. The stainless steel buttons and matte finish plastic on this phone is just much better looking than its competitors. The Lenovo A6000 on the other hand does have a traditional bar design, but we find it a little too boring against the Mi device.

Nevertheless, there's a lot more to build and design than just looks. For example, the rubberised grip around the Moto E (2nd Gen) provides protection against falls that its competitors don't have. Yes, smartphones are least vulnerable when dropped on their sides, but a little more protection never hurts right?

Of course, Motorola's design choices don't allow for a removable battery, which is an area that the Redmi 2 and A6000 have covered. But that's just a design choice.

All things considered, it is the Redmi 2 which seems to strike the right balance between looks and sturdiness. The Mi device is also light and while not as sturdy as the Moto E, it's still a well-built smartphone. So we would go for the Redmi 2 in this segment.

Ergonomics/Usability

The next aspect that we need to establish is how easy it is to operate these phones while travelling or in crowded places. The largest of the three devices is the Lenovo A6000, with a 5 inch display and about a 5.5 inch frame. This is the overall length of the phone mind you. The Moto E is the smallest, with a 4.5 inch display and around a 5 inch frame.

It's very difficult to choose here, since the Redmi 2, even though it has a slightly larger 4.7 inch display, is almost the same size as the Moto E. We'll still go with the Moto E in the ergonomics department though. Motorola started this curved back design with its first generation of Moto phones. The design allows the Moto E, Moto G and Moto X to fit snugly into your hands and feel very natural when you're using any of them. It improves the grip over the phone, which means you're less likely to drop it when using it in a hurry.

The Lenovo A6000 is just plain big and clumsy compared to the other two phones, but the Redmi 2 loses out to the Moto E here by a very small margin.

Performance

Motorola made a very surprising choice of processors for the new version of the Moto E. The company chose the quad-core version of the Snapdragon 200, which offers very little over the older dual-core version running on the first gen Moto E. In comparison, both the A6000 and Redmi 2 come with new generation 64-bit Snapdragon 410 SoCs.

It's a big loss for the Moto E here. If you're a Moto fan, you can take solace in the fact that the Snapdragon 410 isn't particularly strong in the GPU department, which allows for a smaller margin between the Redmi, A6000 and Moto E, but the Lenovo and Xiaomi devices are still better performers.

The benchmarks show the difference pretty clearly. The Moto E falls short in the processor department and is closer in the graphics and gaming segment. The same is also established through real world usage. The Moto E is simply weaker than the Redmi 2 and Lenovo A6000. The difference between the A6000 and Redmi 2 on the other hand can be attributed to the number of extra background tasks running on the A6000 due to the bloatware Lenovo adds.

The pick for the best performer out of these three smartphones isn't difficult. The Redmi



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